made much more money than us cricketers (comparing their national team contracts with ours), with the advent of 20/20 cricket and the IPL, the wheel has turned.

At the IPL auction in 2008, I, for example, was bought for $575 000. That's $575 000 a year for three years – and that's around half of the $1.35 million my teammate Andrew Symonds went for. When you consider that you are paid this amount for only five weeks' work per year, it's pretty decent cash. Game for game, it's better money than the football players in the English Premier League earn.

So a professional cricketer is what I became, and while it might appear that I've had something of a laissez-faire attitude to my chosen sport, that's not entirely true. Yes, I'm only too aware of the natural talent I have for the game – it would be insincere of me to pretend otherwise – and I've never really possessed too much in the way of a game plan beyond hitting the ball towards the white rope (preferably without a bounce) when I've walked out to bat. But that doesn't mean I haven't prepared or put in the hard yards.

In order to prepare mentally for a game, I always use a variety of visualisation techniques I started when I was still a schoolboy. I would always see myself playing the particular school we were scheduled to play and could 'see' myself fielding and batting. I would basically play the entire game in my head. I don't know if it's a gift, but I can almost 'feel' the ball being bowled to me. In my mind I sense the speed at which it's coming and I can gauge the kinds of shots I'm going to need to play … or the ones that I can't.

Because we know our fixtures months in advance, it gives me plenty of time to think about the upcoming games. Three days before a game, I'll start visualising who I'll be facing and what the wicket will be like. Having been around this long, there aren't many bowlers out there I haven't faced before, so that obviously helps too. There's no substitute for experience. I hated hearing that when I was a youngster, but being an old *ballie* now, I now know exactly what those older players were talking about.

For me, the visualisation technique has been even more valuable in preparing for a match than actually hitting balls. I find hitting balls these days a little boring, to be honest. A lot of the time we hit balls just for the sake of it, because we need to be seen to be putting in the hard work. Fielding is a different story altogether, because you can never get enough catching practice. So, ja, my innings is already played out in my mind when